

VACHTANG LICHELI

Causasian Iberia in
the Post-Achaemenid Period.
The Chronology of
the Principal Monuments



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THE CHRONOLOGY OF THE PRINCIPAL MONUMENTS

*Vakhtang
Licheli*

Caucasian Iberia, located in the central part of the Transcaucasus, borders to the East on historical Albania, to the South on Armenia, to the West on Colchis and to the North on the high Caucasus mountain range.

Of the sites excavated in the territory of Caucasian Iberia more than 20 belong to the Post-Achaemenid period; most of these, however, revealed only cultural layers. For the present purpose of determining the archaeological and cultural sequence of these sites, it has been considered useful only to include those which have been excavated more or less completely. These are as follows (Fig. 1): Samadlo and Nastakisi; Tsikhia-Gora; Sairkhe; Atskuri; Uplistsikhe-Bambebi set-

tlement; Bagineti; Sarkine; Ghartiskari; Dedoplis Mindori and Dedoplis Gora.

The excavated remains of these nine sites have here been divided into three categories according to their main function: a) cultic monuments (Samadlo, Tsikhia-Gora, Uplistsikhe, Sarkine, Dedoplis Mindori); b) settlements (Atskuri, Sairkhe, Dedoplis Gora); c) fortification systems (Gartiskari, Bagineti).

Samadlo is situated in the central part of Iberia, on a rocky hill on the right bank of the river Mtkvari or Kura (Gagoshidze 1979). On the opposite side of the river, the Nastakisi settlement is located. It is suggested that these two sites were connected with each other and that Samadlo functioned as Nastakisi's acropolis. The

Fig. 1. Map of Georgia.
Distribution of the principal
monuments.

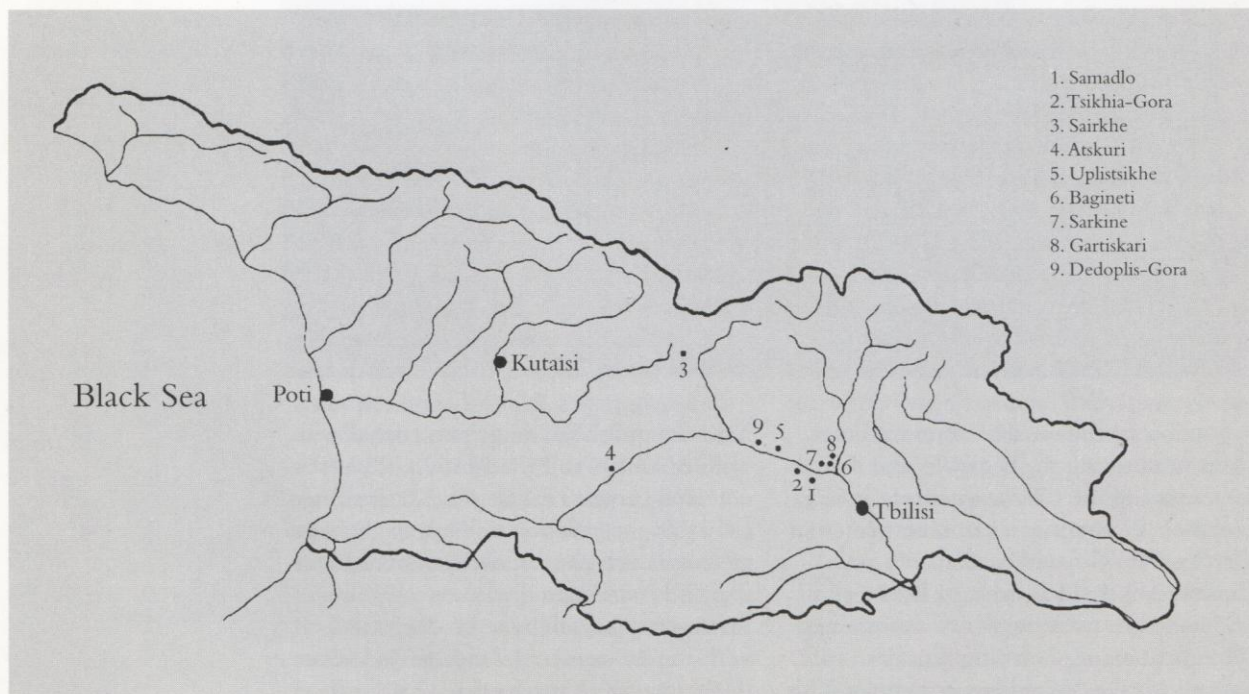
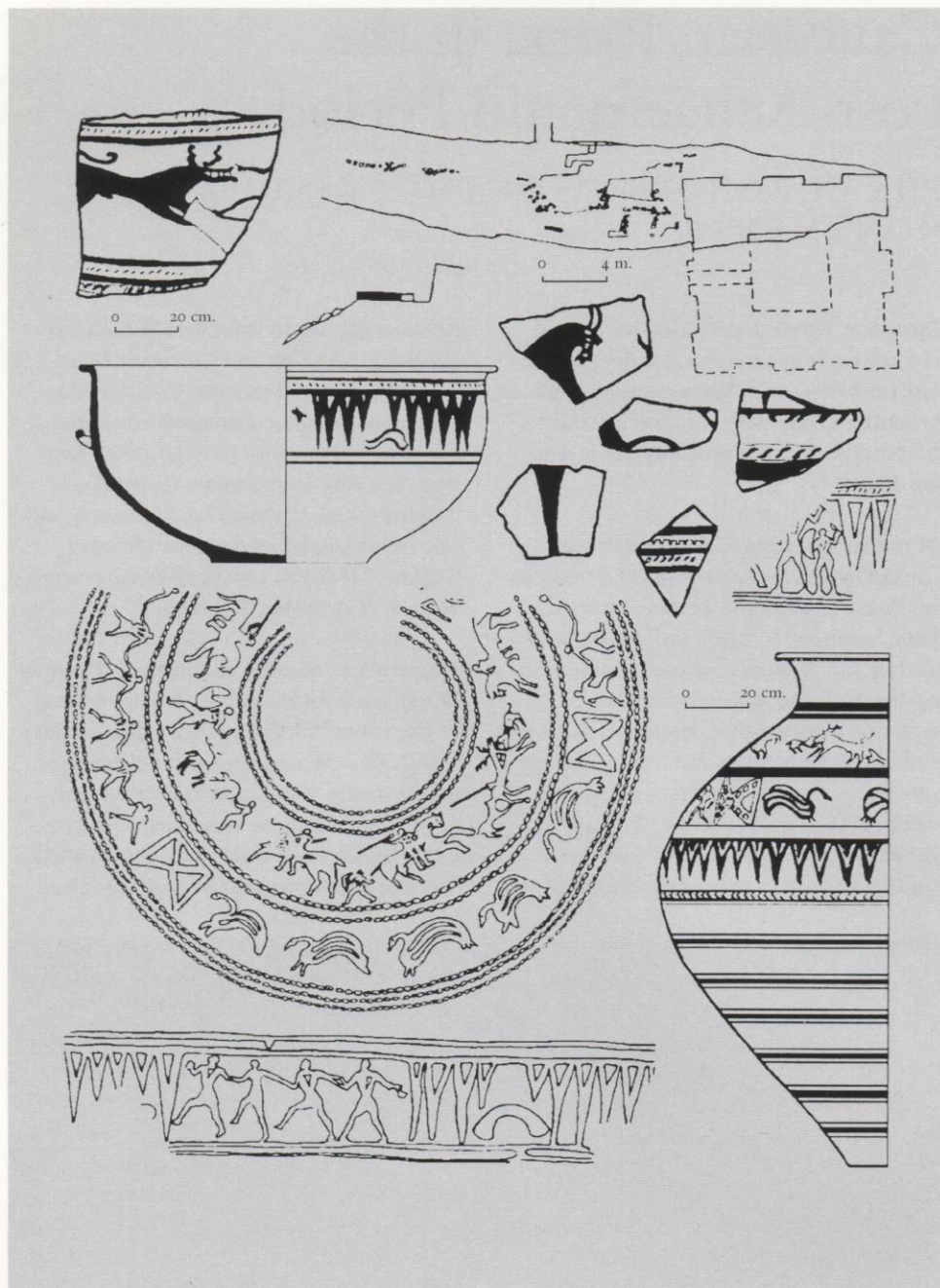


Fig. 2. Samadlo
(after I. Gagoshidze und
O. Lordkipanidze).



separation by the river of a site into two parts constituting the acropolis and the lower part of the City respectively, is a common feature in ancient Georgia (cf. in Colchis, Vani-Saqanchia). Samadlo was destroyed in the 2nd century BC.

The main structure, which determines the function and the cultural position of Samadlo, is the "watch-tower temple." This

is a rectangular building, constructed with walls of ashlars and mud-bricks. It has corner- and central risalites (Fig. 2). Typologically this construction belongs to the type of temple, which was known in the Urartian and Achaemenid periods as a "fire-tower-temple", and may be compared with the Achaemenid Zindan-i-Suleiman in Pasargadae or the Kaaba-i-Zarducht

(Gagoshidze 1979, 51-74; Kipiani 1992, 12-14).

On the hill of Samadlo cultural strata from the 7th-6th century BC and from the Hellenistic period were also excavated, so that three main cultural strata may be identified in Samadlo.

The cited construction could belong to Samadlo's second period (4th-3rd cent. BC), when for the first time unique painted pottery was found in Georgia (Fig. 2). Painted pottery (*pithoi*, *crateres*, jugs etc.) generally appeared in the territory of Iberia without any comparable development in the material culture of the Transcaucasus in the previous period. Therefore this phenomenon should be explained by external influence. I agree that the source of such an impulse could be the north-western regions of Achaemenid Iran (Narimanishvili 1991, 69-80), since the style and the painting-technique of the pottery of Samadlo are close to West Iranian traditions.

As for Nastakisi, this settlement is suggested to be the part of Samadlo's 3rd period, because the layers excavated there date to the 3rd-2nd century BC. Although the archaeological finds are numerous, no Samadlo type painted pottery was found here. The material included locally made pottery and some Greek, black glazed and "West Slope Ware" shreds, as well as an *unguentarium* (second half of the 3rd century BC).

Tsikhia-Gora is located on a small hill on the right bank of the river Mtkvari or Kura, approximately 8 km west of Samadlo. The earliest cultural layers belong to the Bronze Age. In the 2nd half of the 2nd millennium BC, a fairly large settlement developed, which functioned until the 7th-6th century BC (Tskitishvili 1977, 87-93; Tskitishvili 1990, 169-170). After this time, the settlement moved to the nearby valley. Also the hill changed its function, as documented by the discovery of a double-protome capital and the casual find of a bell-shaped column base, which could belong to a layer from the 6th-4th century BC (Gagoshidze & Kipiani 1997,

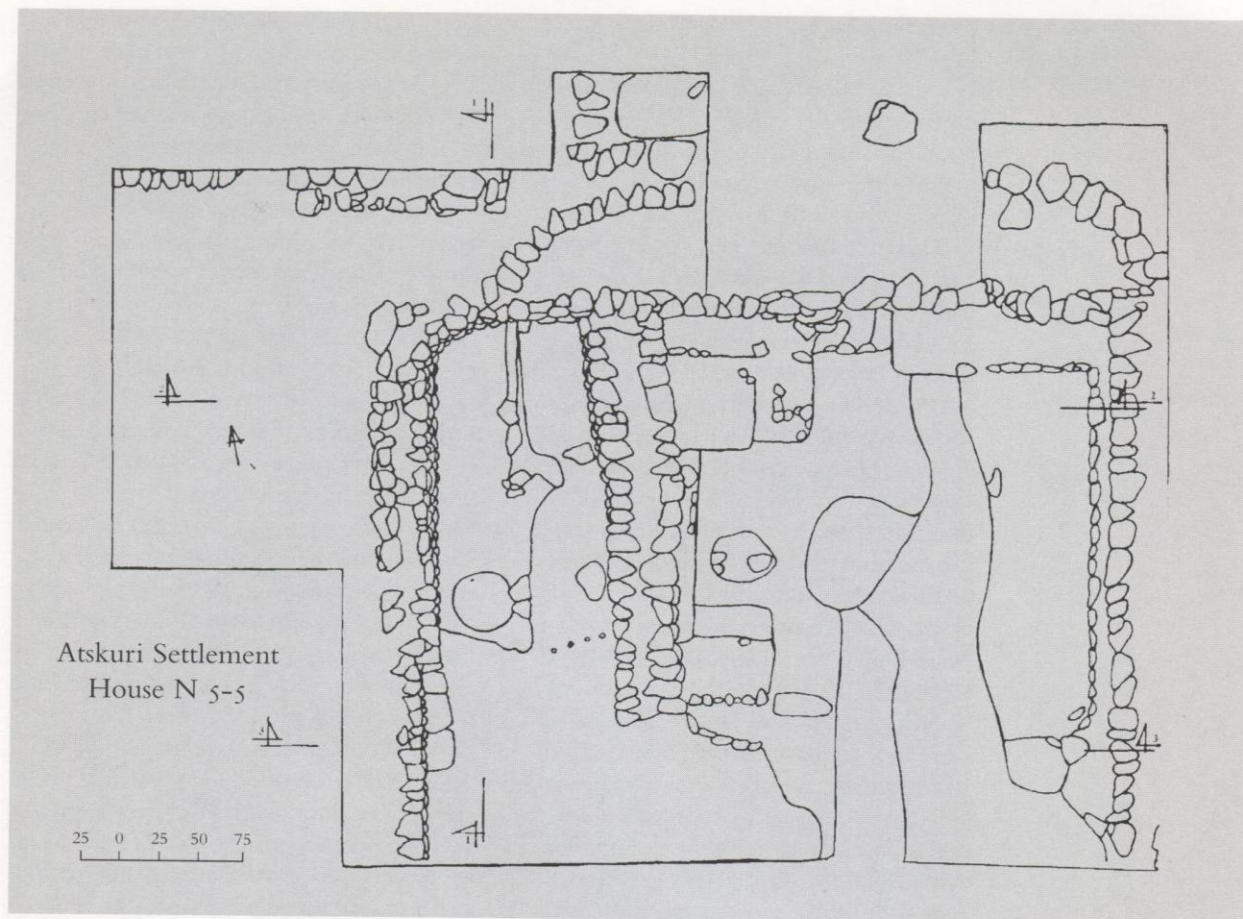
8-11) and which was almost destroyed during the constructional works of the 4th-3rd century BC. The remains of these construction works are in a good state of preservation, especially is that the case with the fortification wall.

Inside the fortification wall several structures were found, among them a temple, built of stone and mud-bricks. The width of the walls was 1.5 m. In the courtyard of the temple was a rectangular pillar with a height 2 m, which seems to be an altar. In the corner of the yard was a square structure of stones and clay (3.5 x 3.5 m), which functioned as a sacrificial place; here an iron knife and burned bones from sheep were found. The temple had two entrances. Some interesting objects were found in the building: clay altar fragments, and disks and bullas with the representation of a horse, a rider and the moon, indicating the existence of the Mithras cult in this area. There is a long building behind the main temple (length 18 m, width 4.5 m), which had two storeys like the main temple. In these premises, on a layer of tile, the double protome capital made of limestone with the representation of bulls was found.

Of other constructions at this site a barn consisting of 6 rooms should be mentioned. Burnt grains, a mill with clay disks inside and 30 hand-mills upon it, and a wine store with 48 *pithoi* of various sizes, were found there. Grape stones belonging to the saperavi grape species, which still exists nowadays were discovered as well, as was an oven for the baking of bread, as well as three dwellings with different ground-plans.

To the North of Tsikhia-Gora, a necropolis with pit-burials of the 13th-1st century BC was excavated. Only one relatively rich grave should be mentioned, in which a disc-shaped, typical Achaemenid golden rosette (diam. 16 cm), figurines, seals and beads were discovered.

In **Sairkhe**, a fragment of an Achaemenid type capital was found several years ago. Sairkhe is the most remote point of distribution of such architectural elements from



the centre of Achaemenid world. This capital is dated to 4th-3rd century BC (Kipiani 1987, 6-12).

The city-site of **Atskuri** is situated on the left bank of the Mtkvari (Kura) river. This is the reason why the south-eastern part of the site was entirely washed away by the river. The stratigraphy is the same in each section of the site: the humus (5-15 cm thick) is followed by a loamy sterile layer (0.8-3 m thick), which in some places (trench 3) is replaced by a sandy sterile layer (5.5 m thick) or by a loose sterile one (Licheli 1997, 91-93; Licheli, Fossey & Morin 1997, 46-48; Licheli 1998, 25-37). The cultural layer directly following the sterile one is of varying thickness (from 1.5 cm, as in trench 1, to 4.6 cm, as in trench 5).

The architectural remains are mainly represented by various foundations built

with cobbles and ashlar, allowing us to distinguish two different types of planning: one rectangular, the other circular. It should be noted that chronologically circular structures are characteristic of the 5th-4th century BC, while in the subsequent period only rectangular buildings occur (Figs. 3-4). It is noteworthy that the circular altar (diam. 1 m) found in trench 3, (made of cobbles) is also datable to the 5th-4th century BC.

The ceramic material falls into two groups: local and imported (Fig. 5). The local manufacture is represented by Colchian (jugs with tubular handles, *pithoi*, cups) and Iberian (painted jugs, *pithoi*, *phiale*, plates, etc.) forms. Pottery imitating Greek forms constitutes a separate group (*luteria*, some types of bowls) and dates to the Late Hellenistic period (2nd - 1st century BC). Imported wares, represented by Ionian bowls dating to the 6th

Fig. 3. Atskuri. Rectangular house from the 5th-4th cent. BC.

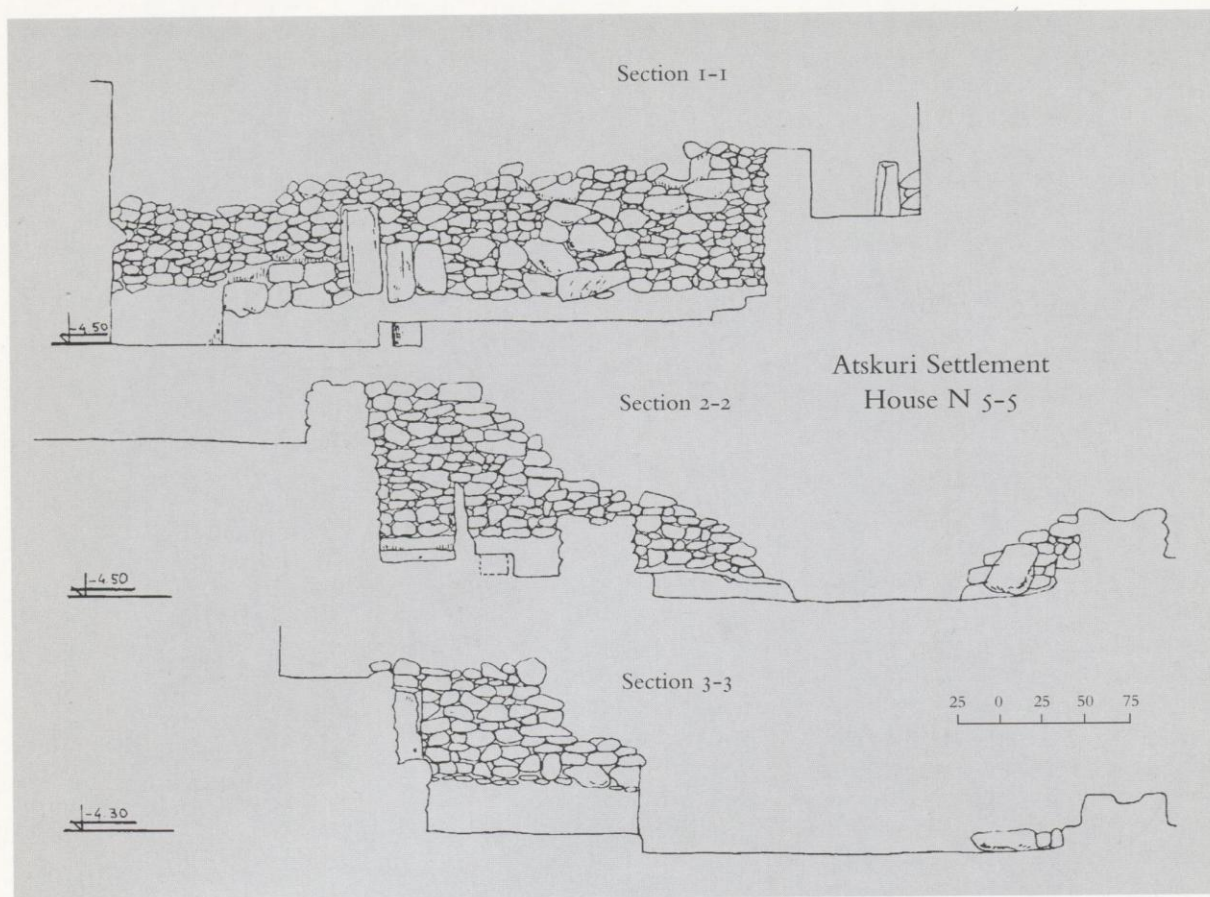


Fig. 4. The Atskuri Settlement. Sections of houses.

century BC (the first example of this type found in the hinterland of Transcaucasia), Attic *kylikes* dating to the 5th century BC, and black-glazed pottery from Asia Minor dating to the 4th-2nd century BC. The discovery of *amphorae* is also noteworthy. According to the colour and fabric they must be the product of a South-Pontic city (Licheli 1998, p. 25-37).

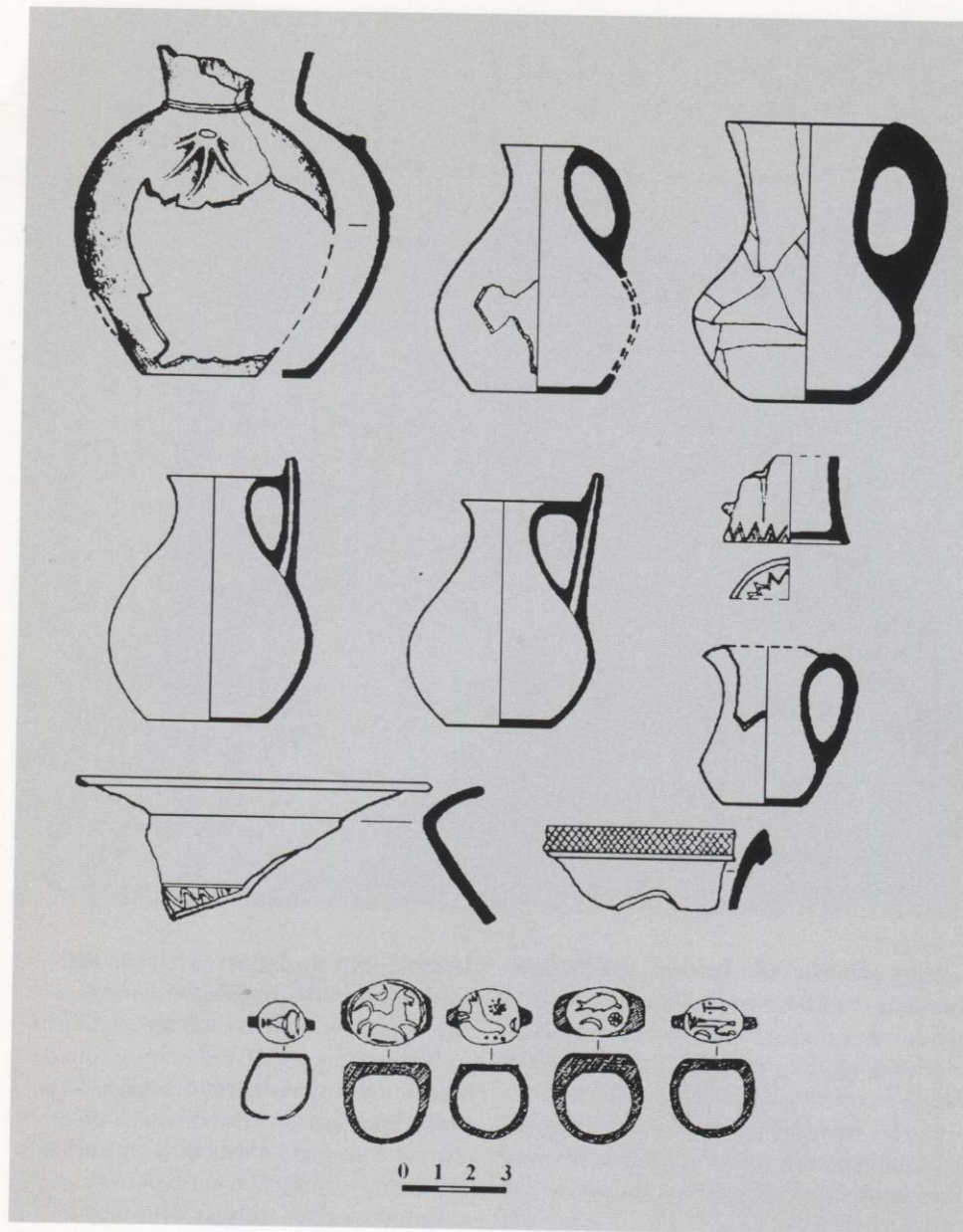
There are several bronze buckles among the artifacts found in Atskuri, which have analogies from Talish and Susa in contexts dating to the late 1st millennium BC, and from Luristan (in the Metropolitan Museum of Art). Worth mentioning are also bone harness fittings like those found in Mashat (North Anatolia), Sardis, Karmir-blur, Gordion, and Persepolis (Koch, 1992, 237; Waldbaum, 1983, 40, pl. 86).

Uplistsikhe is planned according to the morphology of the left side of the river

Mtkvari (Fig. 6), and is carved into the rock. Most of the buildings have cultic functions. There are several sacrificial pits and wine storages (58 *pithoi* were found). Many artefacts of various functions were found here, among which wheels of a chariot with bumps should be mentioned. An analogy for this wheel type was found in Vani (western Georgia). This type of chariot is known from various representations, including from the Apadana reliefs in Persepolis, and belongs to the Achaemenid world (Khakhutaishvili 1963; 1964; Sanikidze 1987). This site is unique for the Hellenistic period of Georgia.

Bagineti is the acropolis of the ancient capital of Iberia, Mtskheta. It is located near the junction of the two rivers Mtkvari and Aragvi, on a high triangular hill. The fortification wall borders an area of approximately 30 hectares. The structures

Fig. 5. Atsquri. Locally made pottery and finger-rings, 5th-4th cent. BC.



are dated approximately to the 2nd -1st century BC (Apakidze 1963, 214).

The main part of the settlement of **Sarkine** has been destroyed, but some parts of the city wall constructed of mud-bricks (2nd -1st century BC) have been preserved. In Sarkine, a Ionian capital (2nd -1st century BC) and masks depicting Dionysus and Ariadne, as well as a Maenad were found.

Ghartiskari. This big, fortified system protected the capital of Iberia from the north (Apakidze et al. 1985, 45). The fortifications of Ghartiskari were probably constructed in the 2nd-1st century BC.

Dedoplis Mindori and Dedoplis

Gora. The great temple of Dedoplis Mindori and the palace of Dedoplis Gora are dated to 1st century BC-1st century AD. The excavated material reveals close relations with the countries of the Orient

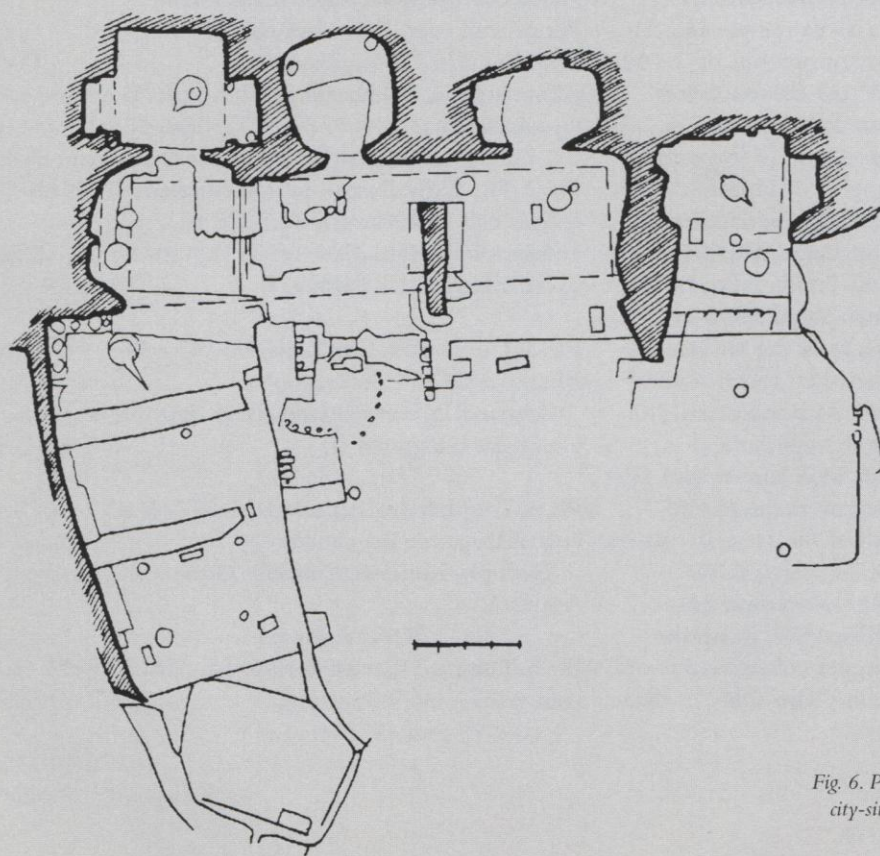
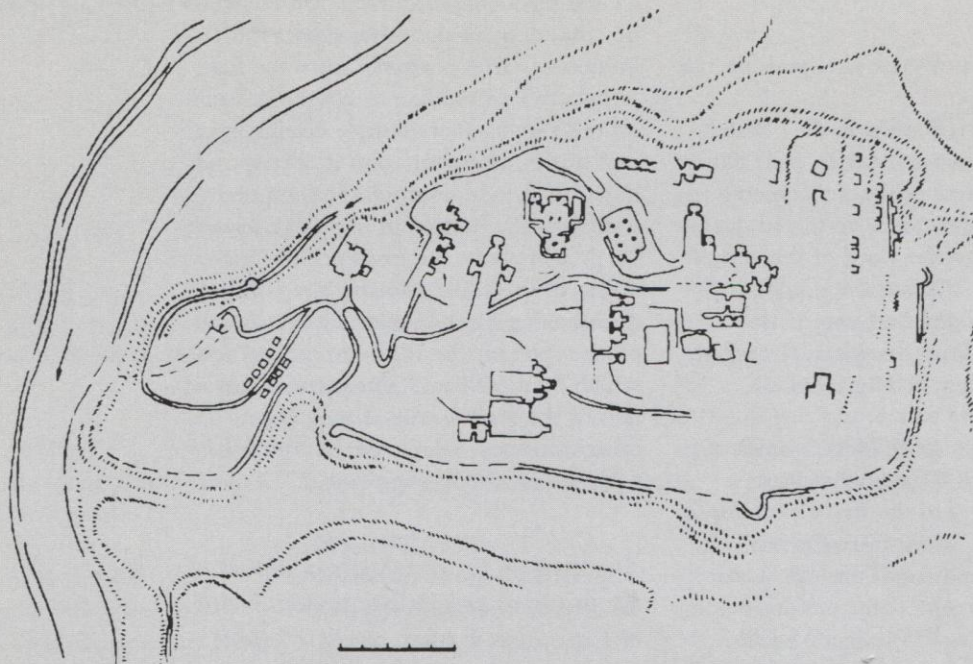


Fig. 6. Plan of the Uplistsikhe city-site, and of the so-called "big house," plan (after T. Sanikidze).

(Gagoshidze 1977, 102-08, and in this volume).

The comparison of these sites presents the following picture:

The second layer of Samadlo ("watch-tower") is contemporary with the Tsikhia-Gora cultural strata of the Achaemenid period. These layers were destroyed during the new construction work of the end of the 4th century BC, but the double protome capital and the bell-shaped base were preserved from that phase. I suggest, therefore, that they belong to an Achaemenid-style palace, and that these structures may illustrate Iberia's unification in the eighteenth Achaemenid Satrapy. They thus belong to the first chronological phase, which lasted from the 5th cent. BC to the last quarter of the 4th century BC. Atsquri's circular constructions belong to this phase as well. The second phase, from the end of the 4th century BC to the beginning of the 2nd century BC, includes the Tsikhia-Gora temple and the rectangular planed constructions of Atsquri, as well as all the cultural layers (so-called. Hellenistic Period Strata) of Samadlo and Tsikhia-Gora. To this period belong also the complex of Uplistsikhe and most of the buildings and cultural layers of Atsquri, with material dating to the 3rd - beginning of the 2nd century BC. To the third phase, which lasted from the 2nd cent. BC to the middle of the 1st century BC, belong the Ghartiskari fortification system, and the layers with masks and Ionic capital of Sarkine, as well as the Bagineti fortification walls and Atsquri IV.

The fourth phase covers the period from the second half of the 1st c. BC to the 1st century AD.

The Dedoplis Mindori temple complex, the Dedoplis Gora palace, and the left bank with the upper cultural layers of Atsquri belong to this phase. Only in the

third phase (=Iberian II, 200-64 BC), do we see some influence from the Hellenistic culture. In all the other phases the influences came primarily from the East.

Finally, I would like to comment briefly on the Tsikhia-Gora temple complex (second phase). In my opinion it corresponds functionally and chronologically quite well with the passage in Strabo (*Geography* 11. 3. 5-6) about the existence of four classes in Iberia. Presumably the constructions belonging to Tsikhia-Gora's second phase represent the Palace of priests, about which Strabo wrote: "The second class is that of the priests, who among other things attend to all matters of controversy with the neighbouring peoples."

Summary of the chronological phases of the principal archaeological monuments of Causasian Iberia:

Ph. 1. The proto-Iberian (Achaemenid) Period: 5th cent. BC - 2nd half of 4th cent. BC.

Samadlo II; Tsikhia-Gora III; Atsquri II; Gumbati

Ph. 2. The Early Iberian period (Iberian I): 2nd half of 4th cent. BC - 200 BC.

Samadlo III; Tsikhia-Gora IV; Uplistsikhe I; Atsquri III; Sairkhe I

Ph. 3. The Iberian II period: 200 BC - 64 BC.

Atsquri IV; Sarkine; Uplistikhe II; Ghartiskari; Bagineti (?)

Ph. 4. The Iberian III period: 64 BC - 1st cent. AD.

Dedoplis Mindori; Dedoplis Gora; Atsquri V

Ph. 5. The Late Iberian Period: 1st - 3rd cent. AD.

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